Chapter 16

The Marriage in Flow

You know the stretch I mean. Nothing between you needs managing. Nobody is bracing for the next thing, and nobody is waiting for the other one to slip. You and your wife are in the same room because you both want to be there, and it’s easy.

That ease is what everything so far has been working toward. The calm and the strength make it possible, and the warmth is what makes it easy.

Part I was the River: staying calm when things change. That calm keeps a hard week from turning into a fight with your wife. Part II was the Oak: the strength to carry weight, so she can lean on you when life gets heavy. Part III is the Sun, and this chapter is where the three come together. The warmth you bring her is what the calm and the strength were for. It’s the capstone, the piece that sits on top of everything you’ve done so far.

The calm and the strength can feel like the hard part, and they are. But if you have both and still keep your warmth from her, you’ve done the work and she misses the best of it. Your attention and your joy are what she actually gets to live with every day.

The old picture.

A lot of us grew up with a different idea of what a man is. Men were fearless. They were protectors. They were providers, and they provided for their families. You can respect that, and I do. The trouble was that it left a man nowhere to put what he felt. A lot of men I’ve known said nothing about what they felt and only spoke up to make a demand. A man bore things quietly. If he

finally was pushed to the edge, it was okay for him to lose himself in anger and blow up.

Calm was my first fix for that, and calm can go cold. In Chapter 1, my calm went cold and I said nothing. One time, I put that cold calm into words and said them to my wife.

I'd just gotten into Stoicism. Not long after, we had an argument. She was angry at me, and I sat there quiet. When she was done, I looked at her and said, "I can't control you. I can only control me and I don't see things the way you do."

She answered right away.

"If I have a man who doesn't care how I feel, if I have a man who believes that he's in a relationship by himself, then he will find himself in a relationship by himself."

She didn't want to be married to a stone.

I shouldn't have aimed that line at her at all. Saying "I can't control you" carried a smug superiority, as if staying calm made me better than her. The idea underneath it was right, and I had used it wrong. "I can only control me" is true. It's a standard I hold my own conduct to. In that argument, it had become a way to opt out of what she was feeling. It should be a mindset, not something that you repeat out loud to her.

What fixed it was turning toward her.

Toward her.

Compassion is where warmth starts. Chapter 2 drew the line between feeling her mood and becoming it. You can feel compassion for somebody without

taking on their emotions. Then you go to her. You sit down next to her and ask what's going on.

I think compassion is a much stronger word than it sounds. It means you want her out of the upset and the worry. You want her in her highest state, at her best, and you put your effort into helping her get there. My wife craves connection, and I crave connection with her. Compassion is how you reach her.

Reaching her is usually small. You put the phone down when she starts talking. You notice she's tired before she has to say so, and you take something off her plate. All it takes is caring how she's doing.

The way I read the Stoics, nothing is good in itself except virtue, which means the quality of your own character. The good things outside it that you hope for are what Chapter 2 called preferred indifferents. They don't decide who you are. Her happiness is one of those things. *Indifferent* doesn't mean you don't care. I want my wife happy.

I'd like to conduct myself in a way that makes our marriage stronger, my wife happier, and helps us get towards eudaimonia. Eudaimonia is the Greek word for a life that's going well as a whole. It's often translated as flourishing.

Every act of compassion you carry out is a gift to your marriage.

Both of you.

As I see it, a relationship is an investment, not a burden. She wants to know the time you give her is time you're glad to give.

I teach my boys that every kind of relationship, not just marriage, is one you invest in over a long period of time. I tell them it's true with their teachers, with their coaches, with their girlfriends. It's true for you, too, and most of all with your wife.

Chapter 6 brought in the Roman Stoic teacher Musonius Rufus, who described marriage as one shared life. I picture that life as a house the two of you own. You live in it every day, and just living there wears on it a little. So you keep it up, and now and then you make it better than it was.

Most of that care is small. I say good morning to her when I'm traveling. I make the coffee. I rub her back. I pick up a gift while I'm out because I thought of her. Your small things will be different from mine. They'll fit your marriage. You know what she'd notice. Each one takes a minute or two. What makes it matter is that you did it on an ordinary day, without being asked, because she was worth the minute.

She looks after the place too, in her own ways. When she feels your attention, it's easier for her to give hers. When you feel hers, it's easier for you. Effort works the same way. Two people who keep putting in make it lighter for each other to keep going.

You still go first. You put in whether or not she has much to give that week. The marriage is yours too, and looking after it is your job as much as hers. As I said in Chapter 12, my grandfather told me: "Put your wife first."

Nobody owes anybody here. She doesn't owe you for the coffee, and you don't owe her for what she does for you. The way I see it, there's no debt. Everything you put in is upside or zero. Every good morning either keeps your life together as good as it was or makes it better. None of it is ever wasted.

Hard stretches come too. A bad month can land on you, on her, or on both of you at once. When one comes, neither of you may have much to give, and you both live in what you've already built. That's when the good mornings and the coffee turn out to matter.

At the start of this book, I said a house can be structurally sound and still feel cold. The calm and the strength make it sound. The warmth makes it a home.

So ask yourself about the life you share. Is it better now than it was a year ago?

In flow.

When all of this is working, the whole marriage feels different. There's a word for this that people in business like to use: flow. You've seen *flow* before in this book. In the Introduction and Part I, it belonged to the River, as the way you keep going when life changes. Here it belongs to the whole marriage, the two of you working together.

The psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi described flow in his 1990 book *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience*. He wrote about being absorbed in something that stretches you without overwhelming you. You stop watching yourself, and the doing becomes its own reward.

My sense of the word is simpler. To me, flow is when everything is going well: you're at peace, and you're at your best. Applying that to a whole marriage is my own step. So is pairing it with three words, two of them Greek terms the Stoics used. To me, they describe what flow looks like for the two of you.

The first word is one you already know. Staying calm and steady on the inside is what Chapter 1 called equanimity. For one person, equanimity means you're at peace. Your marriage can be at peace too, with two steady people in it. Then a hard day can be hard without becoming a fight.

The second word is new to this book. There's a best version of you, and a best version of your marriage. Each is the version you'd be proud of. The Greek word for excellence is arête. For the Stoics it meant excellence of character, the same virtue I mentioned earlier. I read it as being at your best. Arête, for a marriage, is the marriage at its best.

The third is eudaimonia, the flourishing from earlier: a life going well as a whole, over years, with both of you in it.

Each word comes from one part of the work. The calm you learned in Part I is what lets a marriage stay at peace. The strength from Part II, keeping your word and carrying weight, is part of what puts it at its best. The warmth in this part is what makes it a life she's glad to share with you. When you're calm and strong and loving at once, the calm, the strength and the warmth stop being separate jobs.

All three words are about the marriage. Being happy as an individual is very different from being happy in a relationship. Being happy in a relationship means you're always thinking about both people. I believe the health of the whole is more important than the health of the individual. Your peace counts, and so does hers.

A marriage is one home the two of you build and keep up together. Keep it at peace, at its best, and flourishing, and it moves into flow.

Most of what a marriage in flow looks like is ordinary. I feel deep joy and deep love for my wife. There's nothing I want to do more than to just hang out with her. I love walking the block with her. I love going to the movies with her. On a regular weekday, that's the whole plan. She's my best friend.

I want my wife to be loved. I want her to feel desired. I want her to feel like a priority. That's what the warmth is for. Your wife should feel all of that from you, on the days nothing special is happening.

You have a lot of people in your life who need you to show up for them. Your kids. Your parents. Your siblings. The people you work with. Your wife. Every one of those relationships matters, and you should be generous with all of them.

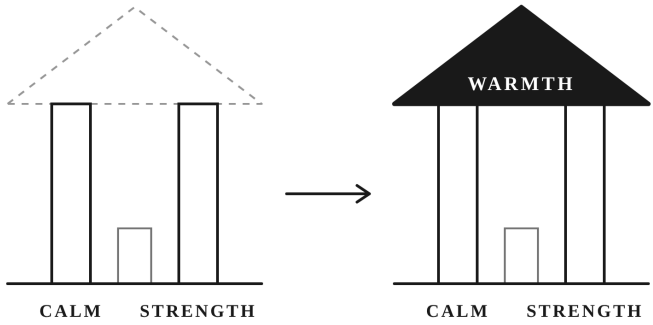
Put the most into your marriage, because she is your number one.

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Putting into Practice

Chapter 16 — The Marriage in Flow

Mechanism: Calm and strength make the marriage sound; warmth makes it a home

The idea in one sentence: Your marriage is a home the two of you own, and you keep it up with small, warm things on ordinary days; nobody owes anybody, and when you're calm, strong and warm at once, it's at peace, at its best, and flourishing.

Warmth is what the calm and the strength were for. Calm alone can go cold. "I can only control me" is true, but it belongs in your head as a mindset, not said out loud to your wife. Warmth starts with compassion. You don't take on her emotions. You go to her, and you want her at her best. Think of your marriage as a house the two of you own. Just living in it wears on it a little every day, so you keep it up and now and then make it better. The upkeep is small: good morning when you're away, the coffee, rubbing her back, a gift because you thought of her. She keeps it up too, and you still go first. Nobody owes anybody. There's no debt, only upside or zero. Calm and strength make the house sound, and warmth makes it a home. When you're calm, strong and warm at once, the marriage is at peace, at its best, and flourishing. I describe those with three words. The first is equanimity. The other two are Stoic Greek: arête, which means excellence, and eudaimonia, a life going well as a whole. That's what flow looks like for a marriage.

Lesson: Warmth is what the calm and the strength were for, and the small things you do for her on ordinary days are what keep your marriage a home.

Challenge: Tomorrow, before she asks for anything, do one small thing for her because she was worth a minute of your day, and that night ask yourself whether the life you share is better now than it was a year ago.

PRACTICE

1. **Proactive.** Every day, without being asked, do one small thing for your wife because you thought of her. Make the coffee, rub her back, or say good morning when you're away.
2. **Reactive.** When she's upset with you and you feel the urge to tell her what you can and can't control, keep that thought to yourself. Sit down next to her and ask what's going on.
3. **Reactive.** When she starts talking, put your phone down. When you notice she's tired before she says so, take something off her plate.